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1919, The Lahore File

In the Lahore Archives, there lies a large file stamped as ‘Secret’. It was written in the immediate aftermath of the Amritsar Massacre 1919 and followed the unrest in Punjab at the time.[1] On 28 May 1919, Chief Secretary to the Government of Punjab J.P. Thompson wrote on behalf of the lieutenant-governor of Punjab to all the commissioners and deputy commissioners of Punjab, asking them to report on ‘the immediate causes of the outbreak in the districts where outbreaks . . . actually occurred’.[2] This was particularly because ‘[t]he introduction of Martial Law was a novel experiment in this country, and in examining the method in which it has been administered, there should be no hesitation in drawing attention to what actual experience has shown to be unnecessary or undesirable’. After all, ‘prompt’ action ‘of the military authorities checked the spread of disorder and in all probability saved the province from a state of temporary anarchy’. [3] On this basis, what the lieutenant-governor of Punjab now desired was that the commissioners of Jullunder, Ambala and Lahore Divisions, together with the political agents of the Phulkian States and the Bahawalpur Agency, ‘submit brief reports on the recent disturbances so far as they have affected the States in the Agencies’.[4]

The most striking report sent to the lieutenant-governor in this file is by the Lahore commissioner. What he wishes to point out is ‘a very necessary result of the lesson that India is not different from the India of 1857 but the same’. This is quite a remarkable statement to make in 1919. More than half-a-century had gone by since the East India Company was replaced after the so-called ‘Indian Mutiny of 1857’ by direct rule from London. In its aftermath, an iron-clad system of control and administration had been